

City Routes

Beijing → Xi'an → Shanghai:

5,000 Years in One Trip (7-8

Days)

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Beijing → Xi'an → Shanghai: 5,000 Years in One Trip

(7-8 Days)

This 7-8 day route connects three of China's most historically significant cities, spanning from ancient imperial capitals to the nation's ultra-modern financial hub. You'll witness 5,000 years of civilization -- from the Forbidden City to the Terracotta Warriors to Shanghai's futuristic skyline -- all connected by China's world-class high-speed rail network.

Day 1-2: Beijing -- Imperial Grandeur

Day 1 Morning: The Forbidden City (故宫)

Begin your 5,000-year journey at the Palace Museum -- 72 hectares of imperial

magnificence with 9,999 rooms. Book tickets online at least 7 days in advance via the WeChat mini-program "故宫博物院" (they sell out fast). Enter through the Meridian Gate (午门) and walk the central axis to the Gate of Divine Prowess (神武门). Don't miss the Clock Gallery (钟表馆, ¥10 extra) and the Treasure Gallery (珍宝馆, ¥10 extra). Budget 3-4 hours minimum.

08:30-17:00 (Apr-Oct) / 08:30-16:30 (Nov-Mar) | ¥60 (Apr-Oct) / ¥40 (Nov-Mar) | ! Closed

Mondays

Day 1 Afternoon: Temple of Heaven (天坛)

Take Metro Line 5 to Tiantan Dongmen station. The Hall of Prayer for Good Harvests (祈年殿) is the iconic triple-gabled circular building. The echo wall (回音壁) and circular mound altar (圜丘坛) are acoustic marvels -- whisper at one end and your partner can hear you 65 meters away. The surrounding park is alive with locals practicing tai chi and

playing jianzi (毽子).

06:00-21:00 (park) / 08:00-17:00 (buildings) | ¥15 (park) / ¥34 (through ticket)

Day 2: The Great Wall at Mutianyu (慕田峪长城)

Mutianyu is the best section for first-timers -- less crowded than Badaling, beautifully restored, with cable car and toboggan. Book a private car via DiDi (¥200-300 round trip, 1.5 hours) or take bus 916 Express from Dongzhimen hub to Huairou, then transfer to bus H23 (¥15 total, 2 hours). The cable car saves 45 minutes of steep climbing. Walk from Tower 14 eastward to Tower 23 for the most scenic stretch.

07:30-18:00 (Apr-Oct) / 08:00-17:00 (Nov-Mar) | ¥40 (entry) + ¥120 (cable car round trip)

Day 2 Evening: Houhai Lake (后海)

Back in Beijing, unwind at Houhai Lake -- stroll the lakeside, grab dinner at a rooftop

restaurant, or rent a paddle boat at sunset. The area comes alive after 8 PM with street performers and neon-lit bars reflecting off the water. Try 烤肉季 (Rouji) for famous Beijing lamb BBQ since 1848.

24/7 | 酒吧 18:00-次日2:00

Day 3: High-Speed Rail Beijing → Xi'an

The Journey: Beijing West → Xi'an North

The G-train covers 1,200 km in approximately 4 hours 30 minutes at 350 km/h. Book via the

12306 app

(铁路12306) -- the official railway booking platform with English support. Tickets open 15 days before departure at 8:00 AM Beijing time.

Ticket prices (2026):

* Second Class (二等座): ¥515.5 -- comfortable 3+2 seating, power outlets at every seat

* First Class (一等座): ¥824.5 -- wider 2+2 seating, more legroom

* Business Class (商务座): ¥1,624 -- lie-flat seats, meals included

Boarding tips:

Arrive at Beijing West Station (北京西站) 45 minutes early. The station is massive -- follow signs to your gate (检票口). The dining car (餐车) is in car 5 or 8 depending on train number. Watch the landscape shift from northern plains to the loess plateau of Shaanxi as you approach Xi'an.

Day 4-5: Xi'an -- Ancient Capital of 13 Dynasties

Day 4: Terracotta Warriors (秦始皇兵马俑)

One of the greatest archaeological discoveries of the 20th century -- 8,000 life-size clay soldiers, horses, and chariots guarding Emperor Qin Shi Huang's tomb since 210 BC. No photo prepares you for the scale: Pit 1 alone contains 6,000 warriors in battle formation.

Each face is unique. Budget 3-4 hours. Take tourist bus 306 (游5路) from Xi'an Train Station (¥7, 1 hour) or hire a DiDi (¥120-150 one way).

Tip:

Hire an official guide at the entrance (¥150 for 2 hours) -- the stories behind each warrior make the visit 10x more meaningful.

08:30-18:00 (Mar-Nov) / 08:30-17:30 (Dec-Feb) | ¥120 | ! Book online via WeChat

mini-program "秦始皇帝陵博物院"

Day 4 Evening: Muslim Quarter (回民街)

Xi'an's most famous food street -- a bustling labyrinth of Muslim-Chinese culture dating

back 1,300 years to the Silk Road era. The narrow lanes around Huimin Jie (回民街) and Beiyuanmen (北院门) are packed with hundreds of stalls. Must-try: 肉夹馍 (ròu jiā mó, "Chinese hamburger" -- braised pork in a crispy flatbread, ¥15), 羊肉泡馍 (yáng ròu pào mó, torn bread soaked in lamb soup, ¥35), 甑糕 (zèng gāo, sticky rice cake with dates, ¥10), and 红柳烤肉 (hóng liǔ kǎo ròu, lamb skewers on red willow sticks, ¥10 each).

24/7 (outdoor area) | Free (entry) | Budget ¥50-80/person for a food crawl

Day 5 Morning: Xi'an City Wall Bike Ride (西安城墙骑行)

The best-preserved ancient city wall in China -- 13.7 km of massive Ming Dynasty fortifications (1370 AD) circling the old city, 12 meters high and 15 meters wide at the top. Rent a bicycle (¥45/3 hours for single, ¥90/3 hours for tandem) and ride the entire loop -- it takes 1.5-2 hours at a leisurely pace. The south gate (南门, Yongning Gate) is the most photogenic with its drawbridge and moat. Sunset from the wall is spectacular.

08:00-22:00 (Apr-Oct) / 08:00-19:00 (Nov-Mar) | ¥54 (entry) + ¥45 (bike rental 3h)

Day 5 Afternoon: Bell Tower (钟楼) & Big Wild Goose Pagoda (大雁塔)

The Bell Tower (钟楼) sits at the exact center of Xi'an -- the geographic heart of the ancient capital. Built in 1384, it houses a massive 6-ton bronze bell. Cross the underground passage to the nearby Drum Tower (鼓楼, ¥30 combined ticket). Then take Metro Line 3 south to the Big Wild Goose Pagoda (大雁塔) -- a 64m-tall Buddhist pagoda built in 652 AD to house scriptures brought from India by the monk Xuanzang. The surrounding Da Ci'en Temple (大慈恩寺) complex is serene. At night, the North Square fountain show (音乐喷泉, free) is Asia's largest musical fountain.

钟楼 08:30-21:30 / 大雁塔 08:00-18:30 | 钟楼+鼓楼 ¥50 / 大慈恩寺 ¥40 / 大雁塔登塔 ¥30

Day 6: High-Speed Rail Xi'an → Shanghai

The Journey: Xi'an North → Shanghai Hongqiao

The G-train covers approximately 1,500 km in 6 hours. An alternative is a 2-hour flight (¥600-1,200) if you prefer to save time. For the HSR, second class costs ¥615 and the route passes through Zhengzhou, Nanjing, and Suzhou -- you'll watch the landscape transform from the dry loess plateau to the lush Yangtze delta.

Second class ¥615 / First class ¥984 / Business class ¥1,919

Day 7-8: Shanghai -- Where Future Meets Past

Day 7 Morning: The Bund (外滩)

Arrive at Shanghai Hongqiao Station, take Metro Line 2 to East Nanjing Road (南京东路).

Walk 5 minutes to the Bund waterfront. The 1.5 km promenade faces Pudong's

jaw-dropping skyline -- Oriental Pearl Tower, Shanghai Tower (632m, world's 3rd tallest),

and the bottle-opener-shaped World Financial Center. Best visited at sunrise (6 AM, no crowds) or after dark when the skyline is illuminated.

24/7 (outdoor) | Free

Day 7 Afternoon: Yu Garden (豫园) & Old City

Walk south from the Bund (15 min) to Yu Garden -- a 400-year-old classical Chinese garden with rockeries, koi ponds, and pavilions. The surrounding bazaar (豫园商城) has traditional tea houses and the famous Nanxiang steamed buns (南翔馒头店) -- expect 30+ minute queues for their xiaolongbao.

09:00-16:45 | ¥40

Day 8 Morning: French Concession & Nanjing Road

The Former French Concession (法租界) is Shanghai's most charming neighborhood --

tree-lined streets, Art Deco architecture, independent cafes, and boutiques. Walk along Wukang Road (武康路) for Instagram-worthy shots of the iconic Wukang Mansion (武康大楼). Then head to Nanjing Road (南京路步行街), China's most famous shopping boulevard -- 1.2 km of neon-lit stores stretching from the Bund to People's Square.

10:00-22:00 | Free (entry)

Day 8 Afternoon: Pudong & Lujiazui Skyline

Cross the Huangpu River via Metro Line 2 to Lujiazui. Visit the Shanghai Tower observation deck on the 118th floor -- the world's highest indoor observation deck at 546m. On clear days, you can see the Yangtze estuary. End with dinner at one of Lujiazui's rooftop restaurants overlooking the Bund.

08:30-22:00 | ¥180 (observation deck)

Route Tips

* HSR Booking:

* Use the 12306 app (铁路12306). Register with your passport number. Tickets open 15 days before departure at 8:00 AM Beijing time. Popular routes sell out fast -- set an alarm! Book all segments as early as possible.

* Best Seasons:

* Spring (April-May) and Autumn (September-October). Avoid Golden Week (Oct 1-7) and Chinese New Year -- trains are packed and attractions are overcrowded.

* Budget Estimate:

* ¥7,000-12,000 per person for 8 days (mid-range). HSR tickets total: ~¥1,700. Hotels: ¥300-600/night. Meals: ¥80-150/day. Attractions: ¥800 total.

* Essential Apps:

* 12306 (train booking), 高德地图 (navigation), DiDi (ride-hailing), 美团 (food delivery &

deals), WeChat Pay / Alipay (payments).

* Where to Stay:

* Beijing -- Dongcheng district near Wangfujing or Gulou. Xi'an -- inside the city wall near the Bell Tower. Shanghai -- Jing'an or Huangpu for central location.

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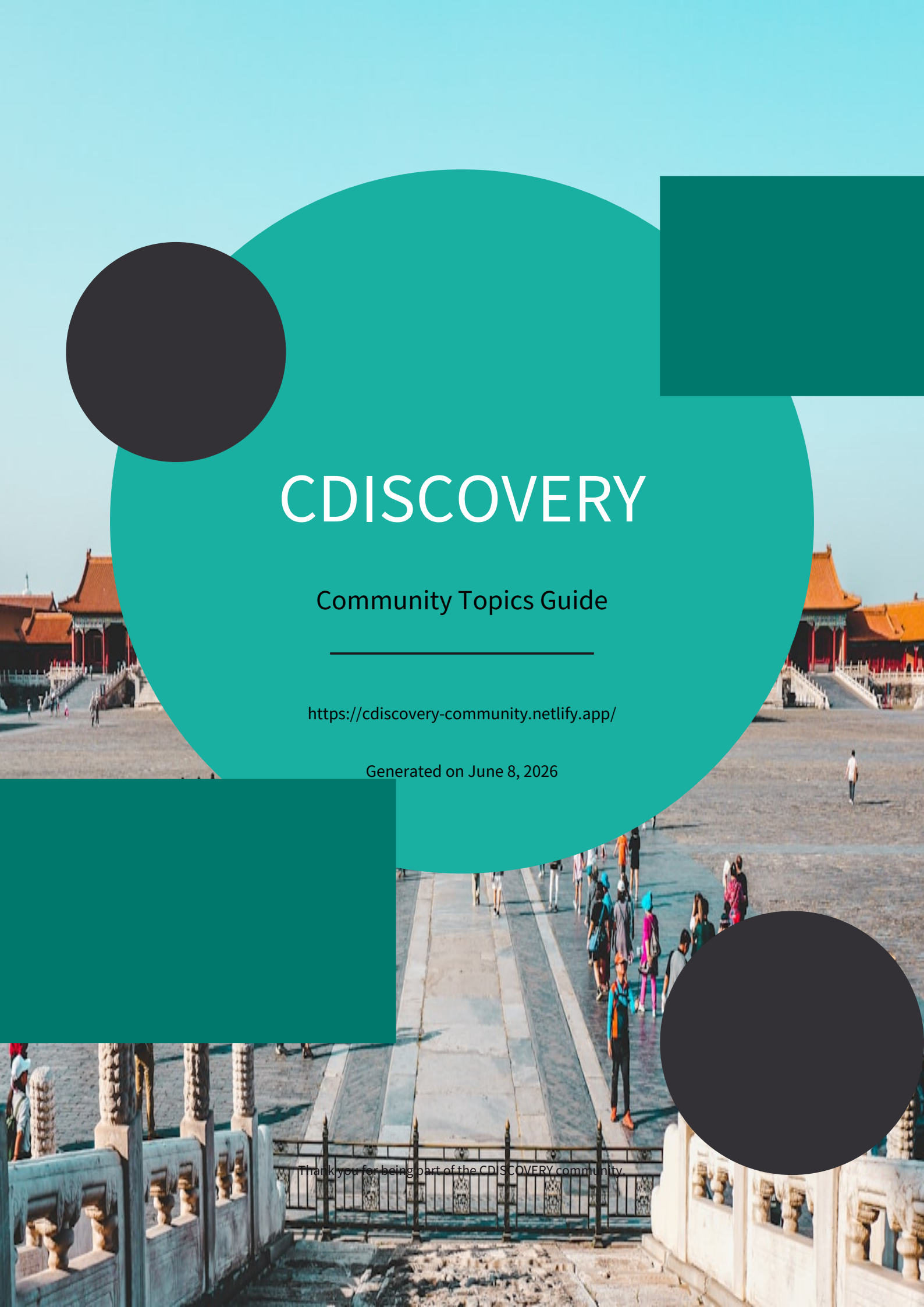
* Booking Warning:

* The Forbidden City and Terracotta Warriors both require advance online booking -- they do NOT sell walk-in tickets. Book at least 3-7 days ahead via their respective WeChat mini-programs.

Sources: Sources: 12306 Official Railway • The Palace Museum • <a href="https://www.bmy.com.cn"

target="_blank">Emperor Qinshihuang's Mausoleum Site Museum • <a href="https://www.shanghaitower.com"

target="_blank">Shanghai Tower



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